

What are the implications of requiring that output groups (e.g. output groups/classes) can be measured in similar ways (called homogeneous output groups/classes)?

In some strategy, planning, implementation and reporting systems, outputs (deliverables) are grouped according to how they are measured. These groups sometimes go by names such as 'homogeneous output classes'. You do this to measure all of the individual outputs in an output group in the same way, then you can easily get an overall summary measure of the extent to which the outputs have been delivered. If the outputs in a group are measured in different ways, then it's harder to create an overall summary of the extent to which they have been achieved. Behind this requirement, there can also be the belief that the ability to summarize achieving the outcomes group means that you can potentially have parties competing with each other to deliver output groups. This approach to output classes theoretically lets you measure which party delivers the best value-for-money, so you can then contract that group to provide the group of outputs.

A useful analogy here is to imagine that you are sending two people to the supermarket (one which does not issue receipts) with \$1000 to buy the ingredients for baking a large number of cookies. You want to work out whether both of them end up spending the money you give them on what you want them to spend it on. To do this, you simply ask them to group what they buy into 'homogenous measurement groups' based on measurement. They might have things that are fluid, things that are measured by weight, and things that are measured by number. This would make it relatively easy for you to check how much they have bought of each for the money you gave them. For instance, how many litres of fluid they bought; what weight of weighed goods; and, what number of counted goods.

This approach makes sense from the point of view of assessing how well different providers are delivering an output group. However, it can create a problem for assessing alignment. This arises if you only show the link between output groups and higher-level outcomes, rather than the links between individual outputs and higher-level outcomes as you can within a DoView strategy/outcomes diagram. This is a specific example of what is discussed in the Outputs/Deliverables Groupings Hiding Links Between Individual Outputs and Outcomes Explainer (C7).